

OBJECTS / 2026 / U.S. AIR FORCE ACADEMY / INTERNATIONAL SPACE STATION

Far Side ISS Commemorative Coin

Cast silver coins for a Space Force research mission



A small edition of hand cast .999 silver coins carrying a Gary Larson Far Side image to the International Space Station.

THE WORK

A mission team at the U.S. Air Force Academy wanted to honor Gary Larson and the curiosity The Far Side has inspired in a generation of scientists, by flying one of his images to the International Space Station and returning it to him. The image chosen was his Earth as a balloon, "Listen, I think we better keep this quiet," first published October 4, 1980. The other face carries the mission's Ad Astra imagery.

THE MATERIAL QUESTION

It could not be a minted challenge coin. A tribute to one artist had to be an object made by hand, in a tiny edition, with no permanent die, every file and mold accountable to the rights holders. And it had to fit a spaceflight payload: small, light, and cleared for flight.

THE MAKING

We translated Larson's 2D drawing into 3D relief, a conversion the mission lead called amazing work, then printed each coin in castable jewelry resin, burned it out, and poured it in .999 silver, about 1.5 inches across and an eighth of an inch thick. The final geometry needed a much larger cup and sprue than early tests, so each coin took far more silver to pour than it weighs. Files and production materials could be relinquished or destroyed at the end of the run, as the permissions required.

IN PLACE

After nearly two years of permissions, proofs and payload changes, the coins launched on May 15 [2026], bound for the International Space Station aboard the Polaris 2026 mission. [Docking / return to Gary Larson: confirm status.]

DETAILS

Year

2026

Location

U.S. Air Force Academy / International Space Station

Category

Objects

Materials

.999 silver, lost wax cast from 3D printed resin

CREDITS

Mission coordination: Maj. Travis Tubbs, U.S. Air Force Academy

Concept: Kyle Melton

Far Side artwork courtesy FarWorks, Inc.

STUDIO

ChiLab Studio

Chicago, Illinois

Established 2013



01 FAR SIDE ISS COMMEMORATIVE COIN



02 FAR SIDE ISS COMMEMORATIVE COIN



03 FAR SIDE ISS COMMEMORATIVE COIN



04 FAR SIDE ISS COMMEMORATIVE COIN



05 FAR SIDE ISS COMMEMORATIVE COIN



06 FAR SIDE ISS COMMEMORATIVE COIN

Bring us a drawing, a model, or a hunch.

THE STUDIO

Specialty material projects for architecture, interior design, public art, and the fine arts.

ChiLab Studio, Chicago, Illinois. Established 2013.

WHAT WE DO

Metal casting

Glass

Finishes

Digital fabrication

Metal fabrication

Restoration

Project management

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